Empowering Students Through Financial Literacy: An Evaluation of NGPF's High School Curriculum

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Abstract

This study investigates the effectiveness of an eight-week structured financial literacy program in improving high school students' knowledge retention and conceptual understanding of personal finance. Utilizing the Next Gen Personal Finance (NGPF) curriculum, 24 students in grades 9-11 at Bergen County Technical High School participated in weekly sessions covering budgeting, banking, credit, investing, and risk management. A 25-question pre- and post-assessment, along with a chi-squared analysis, was used to evaluate learning outcomes. Results showed a statistically significant improvement, with the average score rising from 15.79 to 19.73 and the median from 16 to 21. The distribution of scores shifted upward, and students across all performance levels demonstrated growth. These findings provide empirical support for implementing structured, curriculum-driven financial education in high schools, highlighting the program's potential for scalability, equity, and long-term impact.

Keywords: Financial literacy, curriculum evaluation, high school education, student learning outcomes, pre/post-test analysis, quantitative research, education policy, behavioral finance

1. Introduction

1.1 Background & Importance of Financial Literacy

In today's complex financial system, young people face a wide range of financial options that require a solid foundation in financial literacy. Financial literacy refers to the knowledge and skills necessary to enable individuals, households, and society to make informed financial decisions (Harvard College) The high use of credit cards, student loans, and online financial services, including online banking and cryptocurrency, highlights the need for financial education at a younger age (Lusardi & Mitchell, 2014). However, many high school graduates lack adequate basic financial competencies, which lead to challenges in budgeting, saving, managing credit, and preventing debt (Lin et al., 2022). According to the 2020 “Results of the Program for International Student Assessment” (PISA), one in every five American teenagers (22 percent) lacks basic financial capability competencies (OECD). These trends indicate a growing disparity between access to financial tools and the capacity to utilize them responsibly. However, young people today are exposed to more financial tools and choices than ever before, a significant and well-documented gap persists between this early exposure and their actual financial preparedness. Without structured education, many students graduate lacking the foundational skills necessary to make informed decisions, which often results in long-term financial instability.

Although students today are exposed to more financial tools than ever before, a clear gap remains between early exposure and actual preparedness. Without structured education, many graduates lack the foundational skills needed to make informed choices, which can lead to lasting financial instability.

Empirical evidence has consistently demonstrated that financial education has a positive impact on the financial behavior and long-term financial health of learners. A review of financial literacy programs in U.S. high school financial education found that program participants exhibited improved financial knowledge, better budgeting behavior, and a higher likelihood of making informed financial decisions (Kaiser & Menkhoff, 2019). Participants in financial literacy programs often experience higher financial security, as evidenced by higher savings rates and lower financial stress (Özdemir and Uyanik, 2021). Additionally, research indicates that state-level financial education mandates are associated with higher credit scores and lower loan default rates among young adults (Urban et al., 2020). These programs have been shown to produce long-term impacts, with students retaining strong financial behaviors well into adulthood (Fernandes, Lynch, & Netemeyer, 2014).

This evidence supports the argument that structured instruction during adolescence, rather than informal exposure or trial-and-error learning experiences, is crucial in preparing students for lifelong financial well-being. Additionally, studies have demonstrated that well-structured financial education programs can substantially enhance high school students' financial knowledge. For instance, a study using the Financing Your Future curriculum found statistically significant gains in student understanding across various personal finance concepts, regardless of the course or student background (Walstad, Rebeck, & MacDonald, 2010). This supports the idea that clearly defined and consistently implemented curricula can have a positive impact on student outcomes in financial education. Building on this foundation, growing evidence further emphasizes that the structure and consistency of these programs, particularly when mandated at the state level, can lead to measurable financial outcomes well into adulthood. Growing evidence suggests that systematized financial education programs have a considerable impact on

improving various financial outcomes. The evidence from financial education mandates in high school curricula across different states indicates that these states exhibit better credit scores and lower default rates among young adult populations compared to their counterparts in states without such requirements (Urban et al., 2020). In addition, financial education programs have long-term effects, such that participants in systematized learning continue to exhibit proficient financial decision-making capabilities in their adult lives (Fernandes, Lynch, & Netemeyer, 2014). The evidence supports the need to include systematized financial education programs in high school curricula, equipping students with the fundamental financial knowledge that is paramount to achieving long-term success.

2. Literature Review

2.1 The Role of Next-Gen Personal Finance (NGPF)

The Next Gen Personal Finance (NGPF), a nonprofit organization dedicated to financial education, was founded in 2014 by Tim Ranzetta and Jessica Endlich. Their curriculum is one of the most widely used financial education programs in the United States. NGPF presents a set of high-quality, free educational resources that cover basic financial topics, including budgeting, banking, managing credit, investing strategies, and taxes (Next Gen Personal Finance). The curriculum is unique in that it is interactive, utilizing realistic case studies, simulations, and experiential exercises to facilitate both learning and recall. The ubiquity of its use, coupled with its comprehensiveness, has resulted in more than 70% of high schools in the United States adopting NGPF, making it one of the most widely used financial education programs in the country (Next Gen Personal Finance). This widespread use demonstrates NGPF's reach and relevance in addressing nationwide gaps in financial literacy among young people.

Additionally, a 2024 report by Tyton Partners estimates that students who complete a

one-semester personal finance course, such as NGPF's, may realize up to $100,000 in lifetime financial benefit due to improved behaviors and decision-making. This finding further supports NGPF's credibility and underscores the real-world impact of structured high school financial education (Tyton Partners, 2024).

Existing studies indicate that NGPF has a profoundly positive impact on improving financial knowledge, budgeting, and overall financial behavior among students (Walstad, Rebeck, & MacDonald, 2010). The curriculum was carefully developed to meet national financial literacy standards, providing students with a wide range of knowledge that enables them to make informed financial decisions (Jump$tart Coalition, 2017). With its high standing, empirical evidence, and strict adherence to national educational standards, NGPF was selected as the primary curriculum for this study.

2.2 Gaps in Existing Research

Financial literacy has been widely studied; however, most studies examine overall patterns rather than the effectiveness of a particular program. In the work of Lusardi and Mitchell (2014), several advantages of financial literacy for long-term financial security are established; however, their work primarily examines gaps in the financial knowledge of adults rather than high school financial literacy programs. In a review of Fernandes, Lynch, and Netemeyer (2014), which found that financial education improves financial behavior, the authors do not verify whether high school programs, such as those offered by NGPF, enable students to recall knowledge after a period using a pre/post-test design. Such studies provide general details regarding financial literacy, yet do not demonstrate precisely to what extent financial literacy instruction is planned in high school. This study addresses the lack of research evaluating short-term knowledge retention in high school financial literacy programs, specifically through a structured pre- and

post-test design using the NGPF curriculum. A similar approach was taken in a study by Cude et al. (2006), which utilized pre- and post-test data to classify types of learning, including retained, positive, and zero knowledge gain, among college freshmen. While their focus was on university-level instruction, the study reinforces the value of analyzing what students truly retain from financial education and highlights the importance of differentiating between new learning and pre-existing knowledge. By narrowing the focus to a single curriculum and applying a pre- and post-test model, this research aims to provide clearer insight into instructional outcomes that are often overlooked in broad national assessments.

There is also a significant issue regarding existing studies in that there is no appropriate use of a pre/post-test design to determine to what extent students learn over time. Most studies assess students' financial knowledge at a specific point in time rather than observing it over a structured course (Burku et al., 2021). In studies that report states with personal finance instruction have better financial decisions and credit scores (Urban et al., 2020), there is no evidence on what methods of instruction work or if students recall learning after high school. Such a lack of evidence means that policymakers and educators lack helpful knowledge regarding financial literacy programs that can provide more long-term financial security.

This study aims to address this gap by investigating the following research question: *To what extent does an eight-week NGPF curriculum improve financial literacy among high school students at Bergen County Technical High School?*

3. Methodology

3.1 Study Design

This study utilized a quantitative, pre-experimental research design to assess the effectiveness of an eight-week structured financial literacy program. The program was conducted

over eight weeks, ranging from February 5th to April 30th, 2025, with a total of 8 lessons drawn from the NGPF curriculum. The students participated in one session per week, each lasting 1 hour and 15 minutes. Lessons were strategically selected from the Next Gen Personal Finance (NGPF) One-Semester Course, ensuring coverage of the 10 core financial literacy units, including budgeting, credit, banking, investing, risk management, and behavioral economics.

To determine whether the differences in pre- and post-test scores were statistically significant, a chi-squared test of independence was conducted. The chi-squared test is a non-parametric statistical method used to assess whether there is a significant association between two categorical variables—in this case, students' test performance (categorized as low, medium, or high scores) before and after the program. This test was chosen because it is particularly well-suited for studies where the goal is to evaluate whether a distribution of categorical outcomes differs across two or more groups. In the context of this study, the chi-squared test helped determine whether the observed improvements in financial literacy scores were due to the instructional program or could have occurred by chance. Given the relatively small sample size and the categorical nature of the score groupings, the Chi-square test provided an appropriate and reliable statistical method for evaluating the effectiveness of the intervention.

The test results enabled an objective measurement of learning gains across the entire group, capturing not only shifts in average performance but also the distribution of improvement across performance levels. This analysis helped reinforce whether the program had a consistent impact across different types of learners, adding depth to the overall findings.

To evaluate learning outcomes, a 25-question pre- and post-test unit test developed by NGPF was administered. The test consisted of multiple-choice and scenario-based questions designed to assess student comprehension across various financial literacy topics. The primary focus of the assessment was to measure the percentage improvement between pre- and post-test scores, identify areas of strength and persistent knowledge gaps, and evaluate overall trends in knowledge retention.

3.2 Participants

The study included a sample of 24 high school students enrolled in the financial literacy class. Participants were drawn from grades 9 through 11, ensuring a diverse representation of students at different stages of their high school education. A random selection process was employed to ensure that all students had an equal opportunity to participate, thereby minimizing potential selection bias and enhancing the study's internal validity. Students also chose to be in this project, which could skew the results. Perhaps they joined because they recognize their limited financial literacy knowledge and want to learn, or maybe they joined because they already possess a strong foundation but wish to continue expanding their knowledge. Or perhaps they chose this because they didn't like any of the other project ideas. I think you could add a sentence addressing this potential bias.

To protect student privacy and maintain data integrity, no personally identifiable information was collected during the study. All assessments were conducted anonymously, ensuring unbiased responses and reducing the likelihood of response bias (OECD, 2020). This approach enabled an objective evaluation of the program's impact on student learning and growth in financial literacy.

The study was conducted at Bergen County Technical High School, Teterboro, where a certified math and personal finance teacher delivered the program using the NGPF instructional framework. Two high school students who had previously completed a financial literacy course and earned NGPF certifications also co-taught the lessons, providing peer-led support throughout the eight-week program.

3.3 Limitations

The study included a sample of 24 high school students enrolled in the financial literacy class. Participants were drawn from grades 9 through 11, ensuring a diverse representation of students at different stages of their high school education. A random selection process was employed to ensure that all students had an equal opportunity to participate, thereby minimizing potential selection bias and enhancing the study's internal validity. Students voluntarily opted into the project, which introduces a potential self-selection bias. Some students may have chosen to participate due to a perceived lack of financial knowledge and a desire to enhance their understanding.

In contrast, others may have already possessed strong financial literacy skills and viewed the program as an opportunity to deepen their understanding. Alternatively, some students may have chosen this project due to a limited interest in other available options. This range of motivations introduces variation that could influence the validity of the results and should be taken into account when interpreting the findings. Finally, the decision to group test scores into performance categories for the chi-squared analysis, while helpful in identifying broader patterns, limited the ability to capture more minor, more individual changes in knowledge. Subtle gains in understanding may have been masked within the larger score brackets.

Despite these limitations, the overall research design was still appropriate for the scope and goals of this study. The pre- and post-test structure provided a clear way to measure learning progress over time, and the chi-squared test offered a valid method for analyzing whether changes in performance were statistically significant. For a school-based project with limited resources, this approach allowed for a reliable and informative evaluation of the program's effectiveness.

4. Findings

4.1 Comparison of Scores

To measure the impact of an eight-week structured financial literacy program, students completed an identical 25-question assessment before and after instruction. Figure 1 displays the pre- and post-test performance of the same 24 students, enabling a direct comparison of individual and group-level changes over time.

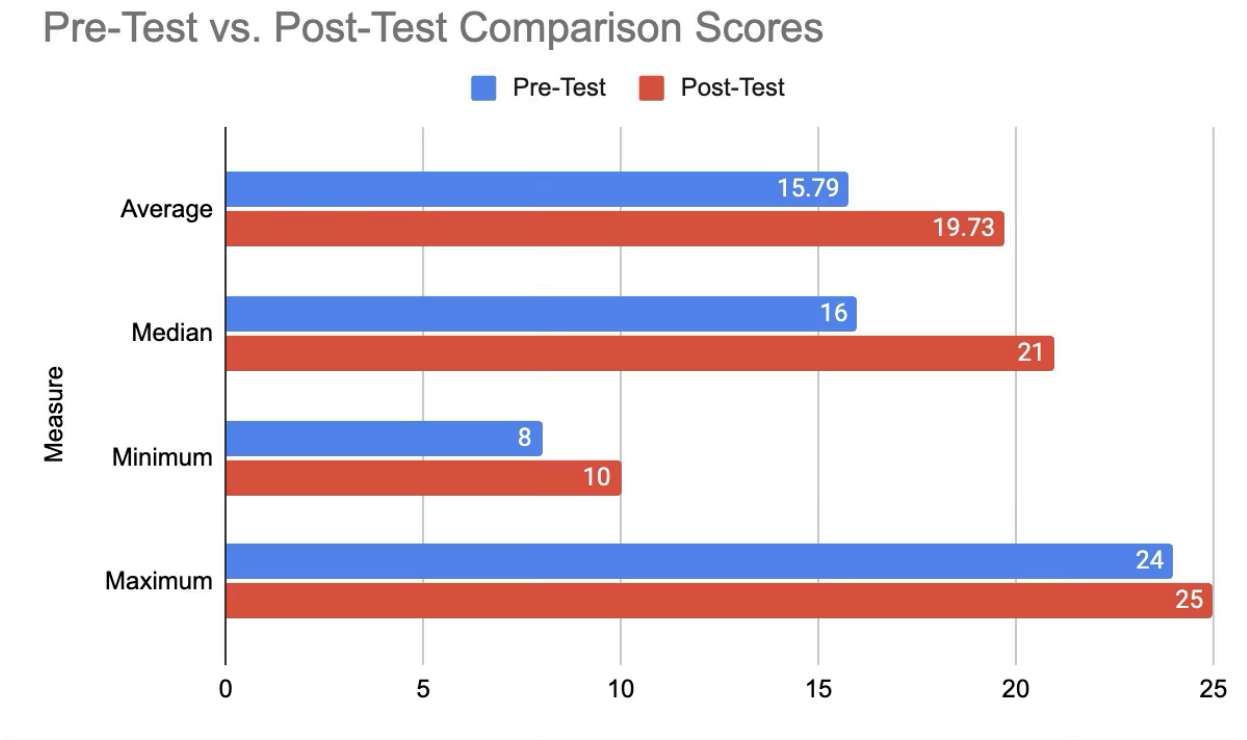


Figure 1. Comparison of student pre- and post-test scores following an eight-week financial literacy program.

The data reveals a consistent upward trend in performance across all key metrics. The average score increased by 3.94 points, while the median rose by 5 points, indicating not only widespread gains but also a shift in the typical level of understanding. The minimum score increased from 8 to 10, and for the first time, students achieved perfect scores of 25, suggesting improved outcomes across the full range of student abilities. The observed gains were not limited to a few high performers; instead, the entire distribution of scores shifted upward. The improvement in the median score indicates that most students advanced beyond their original level. At the same time, the narrowing at the lower end and expansion at the higher end suggest more significant equity in learning outcomes and increased mastery overall.

These changes suggest that the instruction influenced how students interacted with and internalized the material. Learning gains were not superficial or short-lived; instead, the data reflect deeper retention and understanding that extended beyond rote memorization. The post-test performance distribution indicates a re-centering toward higher scores, suggesting that students not only recalled information but also applied concepts with greater accuracy and confidence.

In essence, the results are diagnostic, pointing to an instructional environment that successfully supports both knowledge acquisition and retention. The fact that no student scored lower in the post-test reinforces the idea that the program was accessible and beneficial to learners across a range of prior abilities.

4.2 Chi-Squared Test

Test Statistics	**Degrees of Freedom (df)**	**Chi-Square Statistic (x^2)**	**P-Value**	**Critical Value**
Chi-Squared Test	3	15.24	0.0016	7.815

Figure 2. Chi-squared test Results comparing pre- and post-test score distributions.

Figure 2 presents the results of a chi-squared test conducted to evaluate the statistical significance of the observed differences in score distribution. Students were categorized into four performance levels based on their assessment scores: Low (0–12), Moderate (13–17), High (18–22), and Very High (23–25). This categorical comparison enabled a comprehensive understanding of how learning outcomes changed after the intervention.

The test produced a chi-square statistic of 15.24 with 3 degrees of freedom, exceeding the critical value of 7.815 at the 0.05 significance level. The corresponding p-value of 0.0016 (<0.005) confirms that the observed distributional changes are statistically significant, meaning they are unlikely to have occurred by chance.

This significance strengthens the argument already suggested by descriptive trends: it directly supports the research question by demonstrating that a structured eight-week curriculum using the NGPF model can produce measurable and statistically significant shifts in student performance levels, addressing the gap in the literature related to short-term knowledge retention from high school financial literacy programs. The instructional program not only improved individual scores but also reshaped the overall performance landscape. More students advanced into the higher-scoring categories after instruction, while fewer remained in the lower bands. This shift indicates the program's role in creating not just improvement, but transformation in student learning trajectories. The chi-squared result adds methodological rigor to the study by quantifying the extent of change in categorical performance. It validates that the descriptive growth in scores reflects a systematic and meaningful learning effect, not an incidental or uneven outcome.

Most importantly, this analysis supports the central claim of the research: that structured financial literacy instruction leads to sustained knowledge retention. The statistically significant shift in performance categories highlights not only improvement but also a redistribution of student understanding toward higher-order thinking. By pairing statistical significance with consistent score increases, the findings demonstrate that instructional design can measurably and equitably impact student learning in complex, real-world subjects such as financial decision-making.

4.3 Implications for Learning

The results of this study reveal more than short-term improvement in financial knowledge, illustrating that structured, time-bound financial literacy instruction can lead to statistically significant and cognitively durable learning outcomes among high school students. This conclusion makes a meaningful contribution to the field of financial education, particularly in response to a research gap noted by Lusardi and Mitchell (2014), who highlighted the lack of early financial knowledge as a key contributor to poor financial decision-making in adulthood.

The observed shift in score distribution, paired with a chi-squared p-value of 0.0016, demonstrates that financial literacy can be taught effectively at the high school level and that students are not only capable of retaining knowledge over time but also of advancing across all performance levels. These findings challenge the common perception that financial behaviors are primarily learned experientially or through adulthood and instead affirm the growing body of research suggesting that intervention at earlier stages has long-term benefits (Fernandes, Lynch, & Netemeyer, 2014).

At the instructional level, the implications are direct: educators and administrators seeking to close knowledge gaps in practical, real-world content areas should consider integrating structured financial education into standard curricula. The gains observed in both low-performing and high-performing students support the idea that financial literacy programs are equitable and accessible, a conclusion supported by Urban et al. (2020), who found that personal finance mandates correlate with improved credit outcomes and reduced debt in adulthood.

From a policy standpoint, these findings underscore the urgency of implementing statewide graduation requirements for personal finance education. Despite growing support, as of 2024, fewer than half of U.S. states mandate standalone financial literacy courses for high school graduation (Council for Economic Education, 2023). The evidence presented here supports the argument that such requirements are not merely symbolic; they produce measurable and meaningful gains that can influence long-term behavior.

The study also carries implications for future research. While the findings are promising, they are limited by the absence of long-term follow-up data and behavioral measures. Future studies could investigate whether knowledge gains translate into actual financial decisions, such as savings behavior, budgeting habits, or responsible credit use. Additionally, longitudinal studies could assess whether retention persists six months or a year after instruction and whether refreshers or practice-based reinforcement yield stronger results.

5. Conclusion

5.1 Conclusion

This study aimed to determine whether an eight-week structured financial literacy program could enhance knowledge retention among high school students. By administering identical pre- and post-tests to 24 students, the research demonstrated a clear and statistically significant improvement in financial literacy scores across all performance levels. The average score rose from 15.79 to 19.73, and the median rose from 16 to 21. These gains were validated by a chi-squared test ($x^2 = 15.24$, $p = 0.0016$), confirming that the observed changes were not due to chance.

These findings directly respond to concerns raised in the literature. While Lusardi and Mitchell (2014) identified a widespread lack of financial knowledge in adulthood, they focused mainly on adult populations. Similarly, Fernandes, Lynch, and Netemeyer (2014) discussed how financial education may influence behavior but did not assess high school-level instructional retention over time. This study contributes a new understanding by offering concrete, student-level evidence that structured financial literacy instruction at the high school level can result in both immediate knowledge gains and sustained retention, closing a critical gap in the existing literature.

Therefore, this study both confirms and extends the work of prior researchers. It supports the conclusions made by Lusardi and Mitchell (2014) and Fernandes, Lynch, and Netemeyer (2014), who emphasized the importance of financial education for long-term outcomes. However, this study goes a step further by addressing a gap they did not fully explore. While their research focused mainly on adults and broader behavioral trends, this study provides direct, student-level evidence using a structured high school program, measured through a pre-/post-test design and validated by statistical analysis. These findings suggest that structured financial instruction at the high school level not only supports knowledge development but also enhances retention, advancing existing research by demonstrating how early interventions can lead to significant learning outcomes.

5.2 Limitations

Despite its contributions, the study has several limitations. First, it relied on multiple-choice assessments to measure knowledge retention, which may not fully capture conceptual understanding or practical application. The format may also encourage recognition-based answers rather than authentic financial reasoning. Second, while the

pre/post-test design shows correlation, it does not guarantee causation without a control group. Third, the study only measured short-term retention; it did not determine whether knowledge remains after several months or impacts long-term behavior.

Additionally, the sample size was relatively small (n = 24) and drawn from a single educational context, which may limit the generalizability of the results. Demographic variables such as socioeconomic background, prior exposure to financial education, or language proficiency were not accounted for in this analysis but may influence outcomes in other populations. A final limitation is the self-selection of participants. Students chose to participate in the financial literacy project, which may introduce potential bias. Some may have joined because they recognized their knowledge gaps and sought to improve, while others may have already been confident in their abilities and were looking for enrichment. Still, others may have joined due to a lack of interest in alternative project options. These varying motivations could have influenced engagement levels and learning outcomes.

5.3 Implications

The results provide compelling evidence that financial literacy instruction, when delivered intentionally and over time, can yield measurable improvements across a full spectrum of learners (Leonard, 2024). The consistent shift in scores across average, median, minimum, and maximum values demonstrates that structured instruction can support both struggling and high-achieving students. This reinforces the idea that financial literacy is not only teachable but also equitably accessible when delivered through a sequenced, scaffolded model. Furthermore, the structure of this program of weekly lessons using the NGPF curriculum offers a scalable, low-cost model that can be replicated in diverse school settings nationwide (Liu & Lin, 2021).

From a pedagogical standpoint, the findings suggest that schools should treat personal finance as a foundational subject rather than an elective or optional enrichment. The instructional model used here supports the integration of financial education into mainstream curricula and provides a replicable framework for other schools or districts. From a policy perspective, the findings align with research from recent studies, including those conducted in Italy and Taiwan, which link financial instruction with improved decision-making and long-term behavior (Mancone et al., 2024).

Moreover, the results challenge the assumption that financial literacy is best taught through experience alone. They demonstrate that when provided with the opportunity and structure, high school students can engage meaningfully with and retain complex financial concepts that are relevant throughout their adult lives. This supports the findings of Mandell and Klein (2009), who argue that high school students can acquire meaningful financial knowledge through formal instruction, especially when the curriculum is well-sequenced and tailored to developmental readiness. The implication is that while experiential learning is valuable, it should not be viewed as a substitute for foundational instruction. Instead, it should complement structured educational programs that build financial knowledge from an early and intentional perspective.

The implications of this study extend beyond classroom success. These findings suggest that structured financial literacy instruction can serve as a scalable model for districts aiming to close knowledge gaps among diverse student populations. The increase in student performance suggests that the program is equitable and accessible, providing meaningful benefits to students regardless of their initial proficiency level. This supports the integration of structured financial education as a core component of the curriculum, particularly in underserved schools where

students may lack access to informal financial learning opportunities. By demonstrating statistically significant growth, this study contributes to the evidence base policymakers can reference when advocating for statewide personal finance graduation requirements.

5.4 Future Directions

To build on these findings, future research should investigate longer-term retention and the behavioral application of these concepts. A follow-up assessment several months after the course would provide valuable insights into whether knowledge decays or persists over time. In addition, integrating scenario-based or simulation assessments could better measure how students apply their knowledge in real-world decision-making contexts, rather than relying solely on multiple-choice responses.

Expanding the study to include a control group would strengthen causal claims, while scaling it to include diverse schools across socioeconomic and regional lines would test generalizability. Researchers might also consider how the integration of technology, gamification, or peer-to-peer instruction affects engagement and retention in financial education. Ultimately, this study lays the groundwork for future inquiries into how structured financial education can be optimized for lasting impact, not only in test performance but in lifelong financial well-being.

This study contributes to the literature on financial literacy instruction by providing empirical evidence of student knowledge gain in a guided curriculum. While the results indicate that structured financial literacy instruction is indeed effective, some limitations suggest areas where further research can focus on refining instructional methods and expanding financial literacy instruction to more students. By closing these gaps, subsequent research can contribute

to the development of more effective financial literacy programs that equip students with the necessary tools to achieve long-term economic well-being.

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